

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Landslide & debris flow

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move away from a slide area if you can do so safely, and obey evacuation warnings. Avoid steep slopes, channels and places downhill from recent burns during heavy rain. Do not cross moving debris or enter a fresh slide to inspect it.

Do now.

- ☐ **Notice warning signs**
01 New ground cracks, tilting trees, unusual runoff or rumbling warrant immediate caution and a call to local authorities.
- ☐ **Leave the affected area**
02 Use an official safe route rather than following a drainage channel.
- ☐ **Avoid crossings**
03 Mud and debris can sweep away vehicles and hide damaged road surfaces.
- ☐ **Report from safety**
04 Give the location and visible hazards to emergency services; keep others out.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Stay away from channels, fresh debris and unstable slopes after the first movement. Do not cross the slide to check a house or search for belongings. Choose a destination outside the runout area rather than simply a higher point on the same unstable slope.

Watch for.

Another slide can follow the first, especially during continued rain.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: notice warning signs. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Another slide can follow the first, especially during continued rain.

Keep essentials within reach.

For landslide & debris flow, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Stay away from channels, fresh debris and unstable slopes after the first movement. Do not cross the slide to check a house or search for belongings. Choose a destination outside the runout area rather than simply a higher point on the same unstable slope. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Return only after local authorities assess stability. Contact a qualified professional about slope or structural damage.

First decision: Notice warning signs

New ground cracks, tilting trees, unusual runoff or rumbling warrant immediate caution and a call to local authorities. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Stay away from channels, fresh debris and unstable slopes after the first movement. Do not cross the slide to check a house or search for belongings. Choose a destination outside the runout area rather than simply a higher point on the same unstable slope. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Another slide can follow the first, especially during continued rain. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Move away from a slide area if you can do so safely, and obey evacuation warnings. Avoid steep slopes, channels and places downhill from recent burns during heavy rain. Do not cross moving debris or enter a fresh slide to inspect it. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For landslide & debris flow, keep the specific hazard in view: Another slide can follow the first, especially during continued rain.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Report from safety. Give the location and visible hazards to emergency services; keep others out. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Landslide & debris flow · official guidance

<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/types-of-emergencies/landslide.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/landslide/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.